TOLL

A game of majorities for two players

Two players | Ages 10+ | 20–30 minutes

Two players place their stones, one per turn, on a 9 × 9 board. Each row and each column goes to the side with more stones on it. Captures, however, happen along the diagonals.

Components

- A **9 × 9 board**: the points are where the lines cross.
- **40 light stones** for White, **40 dark stones** for Black.
- The **thick lines** are the **18 routes**: 9 rows and 9 columns. The **thin lines** are the **diagonals**.

Goal

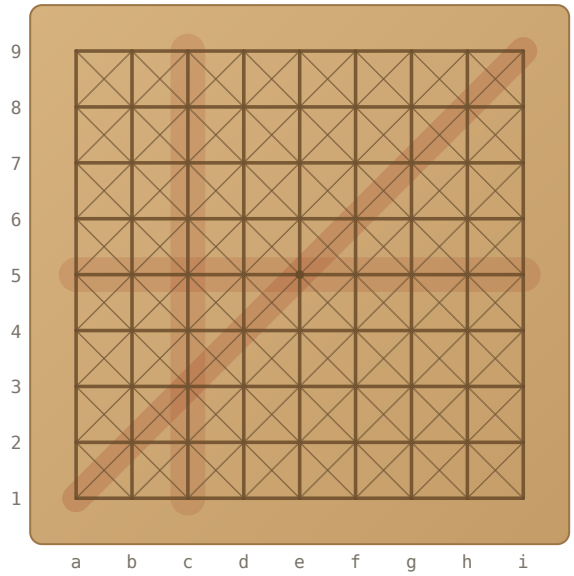
- Hold the most **routes** at the end of the game.
- A route belongs to the side with **strictly more stones** on it. On a tie, it belongs to nobody.
- Diagonals do not score.

Setup

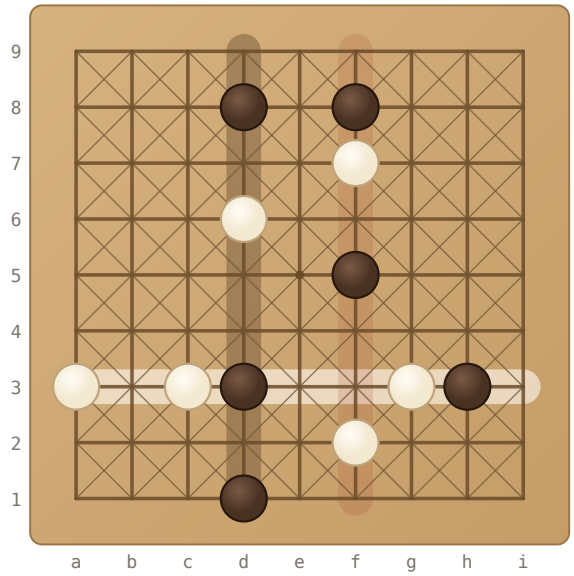
- The board starts empty. Each player takes 40 stones. **White starts.**

Your turn

- **Place** a stone from your reserve on any empty point. Stones never move.
- Then, if you wish, **capture one** enemy stone (see below).
- There is no passing: the game lasts exactly 80 turns, and **Black plays the last one**.



1 Row 5 and column c are two of the 18 routes. The long diagonal a1–i9 does not score, but it is used for captures.



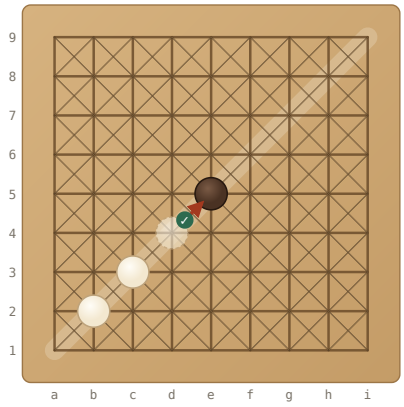
2 Row 3 belongs to White (3 to 2), column d to Black (3 to 1); column f, at 2 to 2, belongs to nobody.

Capturing

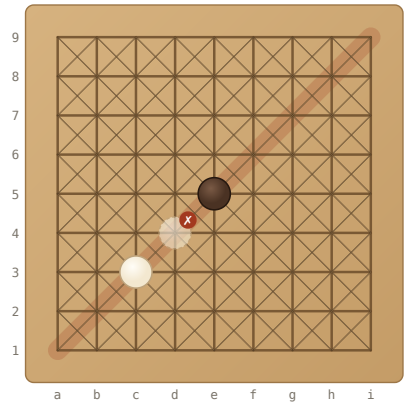
After placing, you may remove **one** enemy stone if both conditions hold:

1. it is the **first stone met** from the placed stone along one of its **two diagonals** (in any of the four directions);
2. on that diagonal, you **already had strictly more stones** than your opponent **before** placing (count the whole diagonal, edge to edge).

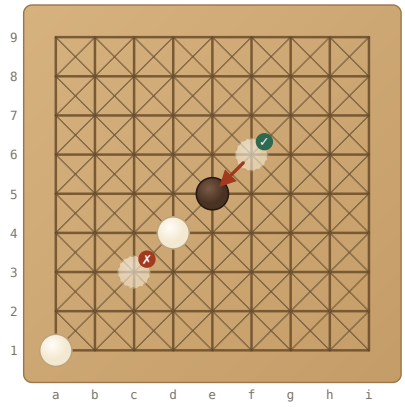
- The captured stone is **removed for good**. Capturing is **optional**, and you **never capture more than one stone** per turn.
- Your own stones **block** the line; empty points do not: you may capture at a distance.



3 White places on **d4**. On that diagonal White had 2 stones to 1, so White may capture **e5**.



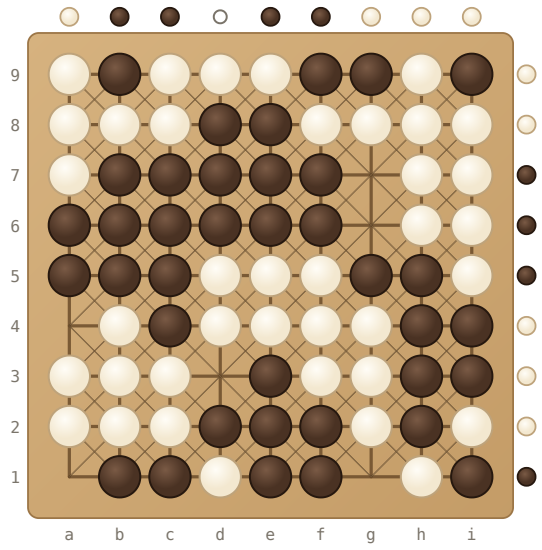
4 At 1 against 1, no capture: the stone being placed does not count.



5 From **f6**, White captures **e5**. From **c3**, White's own stone on **d4** blocks the line.

End of the game

- The game ends when both reserves are empty.
- Each side counts its routes: **the most routes wins**.
- If routes are tied, the side with **more stones on the board** wins (the one that lost fewer). Otherwise the game is a draw.



6 End of a game: the markers off the board show who holds each route. White has 9 routes, Black 8, one is tied: White wins.

GETTING STARTED

- Each stone counts **twice**: in its row and in its column. Look for points where both routes are contested.
- A stone **cannot be captured** as long as its side has at least as many stones as the opponent on both of its diagonals.
- Play **near the centre**: its diagonals are the longest.
- Black plays the last move: White must keep a small lead to the very end.

The player's manual (PDF, in French) covers tactics, plans and the endgame, with solved exercises.